

Interview Guide: Coworkers Supporting a Colleague with Limited Language Proficiency

Warm-up / context

- Can you tell me about a time you worked closely with a coworker who had a language barrier? What was that like day-to-day?

Current experience helping

- Has miscommunication with them ever caused a real problem — a mistake, a missed deadline, confusion in a task? Can you describe it?

Emotional / social dynamics

- Do you ever feel responsible for "carrying" the communication load in the team? Is that fair, in your view?

Reaction to the concept (shared robot for group support)

- If there were a shared device or robot in the room that could help translate or clarify things in real time during team conversations, how do you think that would change the dynamic?

Wrap-up

- What's one thing you wish you understood better about supporting a coworker with a language barrier?

Interview Transcript

Speaker 1 0:02

Hi. So today we're gonna have an interview for the class Deco 3500 Social and Mobile Computing. Just letting you know that your information will be used for data collection, but all personal information will be redacted for you. Do you consent to this?

Sure.

All right. Then I'll just get started. Our project is on coworkers supporting a colleague with limited language proficiency. So, can you tell me about a time you worked closely with a colleague who had a language barrier, and what was that like today, day to day?

Speaker 2 0:44

Well, when you work with a colleague with who's, and English is not their first language, you have to use simple, simple English. Well, I would say your instructions have to be very clear, and to make sure that you convey what you want them to do, and so that they can understand. But the important thing is when you convey it to them, try always not to make them feel that they are inferior to you just because their English is not as good as yours, because remember English is not their first language, but they do have a language that they know better than you and you do not know. So I would say, in most cases, it would not be a problem for them to do the tasks that

you have delegated to them if you show them clearly the steps to be taken, and that would be that would be achievable.

Yeah. All right. Thank you so much. I'll just move on to the next question. Then, has miscommunication with such a colleague ever caused like a real problem, such as like mistake, a missed deadline, or confusion in a task? And can you describe that?

Sure. Sometimes, well, of course, you will expect mistakes to happen, and therefore, the duty is really on on ourselves, on us, to check the work that they produce, so that the mistakes do not go out. Yeah, and if we have done the checks, then that will not be a problem.

Speaker 1 2:48

And do you ever feel responsible for carrying the communication load in the team? And in your point of view, is that fair?

Speaker 2 2:59

Well, if English is not their primary language, then I think it would be naturally fair for me to carry the communication load. Yeah, I think that's that's pretty fair. Yeah.

Speaker 1 3:17

If there was a shared device or a robot in the room that could help to translate or clarify things in real time during team conversations. How do you think that would change the dynamic with communication?

Speaker 2 3:35

If there was a robot in the room, well, I think yes, that should be helpful. But maybe there might be certain, let's say, nuances or certain things that are specific to the industry, or maybe slang. Let's say that the robot may not yet be programmed to understand, and that may be hard to come get across. But I would say, by and large, perhaps the robot can convey at least 80% of the of the substantial stuff. Yeah,

Speaker 1 4:15

and do you think that would improve your conversations in general?

Speaker 2 4:20

I think. Well, if I were there to be the bridge, as like the interpreter, then of course it's not necessary. But if there was no such person to be the bridge, then yeah, sure, robot will be helpful.

Speaker 1 4:38

Right. And what's one thing you wish you understood better about supporting a coworker with a language barrier.

Speaker 2 4:46

Definitely, if I know her language more, that would definitely be useful. Then you can explain it to her in her context, and it would. The meaning would come across much better.

All right. Thank you so much for your time today.

You're welcome.

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